She-Ra and the Princesses of Power - The Third Child. BOOK 3: Rulers of Etheria. ARC 1: Blood on the Sand

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Mature

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by DozenthTurmoil

Summary

The First Arc of the IMMENSELY huge and epic Book 3 of The Third Child!

The Great War begins and all eyes point to the Crimson Wastes, Barely prepared for a war of such immense caliber, Adora leads a group of soldiers into the Crimson Wastes while Gareth joins the fight!

elsewhere, dark forces begin to plot...

Prologue: Dark Tides



Prologue:

Dark Ripples

To say that Shadow Weaver was given a cold welcome would be an understatement, it was more accurate to call it a hostile welcome. Immediately upon being identified by the Soldiers of Brightmoon, she was chained up and brought forward to see the queens of brightmoon.

The sorceress could feel the burning hatred from the crowd that surged forward, but Shadow Weaver could feel a stronger emotion…fear. No doubt the message of Gareth was especially

directed towards this kingdom, the citizens were terrified and they needed someone to take it out on.

Shadow Weaver was such a candidate for emotional lightning rod. This rage provided no amount of comfort as she was escorted through the halls of Brightmoon Castle. Brightmoon has had to deal with the vast tensions fired up by Gareth's Declaration to the entire continent. This threat of war was demanded to be answered by the entire Coalition of Etheria, the united kingdoms of Etheria that have formed from the remnants of the rebellion mere days after the Crimson Revolution took over the Fright Zone.

And Ziadroth grew from the ashes of the Horde like a monstrous oak.

The harsh stormy Spring night of the surrounding landscape was sharply contrasted by the brightly lit interior of the Castle itself, but perhaps the ominous fog that surrounded the entire kingdom had brought the atmosphere and tension in the air up to eleven. This fog was unlike anything the region has had before.

Shadow Weaver was brought to kneel before the throne, in the harsh light the sorceress thought for a second that Angella and Micah were sitting there looking upon her in deep disappointment. Such a thought was dashed in an instant when her eyes adjusted and gazed upon Adora and Glimmer.

Adora had a look of utter surprise upon her face while Glimmer had a hateful glare carved into her eyes, but before the daughter of Micah could speak, The daughter of Shadow Weaver spoke

first. “Weaver?! What are you doing here?” the warrior queen shouted and stood up at the same time.

Adora approached her maternal figure, surprisingly cautious in her steps as if she was expecting Shadow Weaver to unleash some sort of attack. Glimmer reached out to Adora, but retracted her hand just as gently when Adora looked at Glimmer with a small confident smile. A gentle assurance that things will be okay

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath through her nostrils and exhaled harshly. “I have come to offer my services as a court sorceress. The ruling kingdom of the coalition needs a full court, especially in these times of war.” Shadow Weaver stated gently but Glimmer snapped again.

“We could ask Casta now could we?!” Glimmer gritted her teeth in a slowly bubbling anger. “Yes, you could. But Ziadroth has dominion over the black garnet and will no doubt learn to harness its power in the coming months, and I know the power of the garnet well.” Shadow Weaver stated.

“Glimmer, I think it's more important to realize that this is Adora’s mother. Hell this is the mother of Gareth and Catra! She could definitely help us with possible plans they had.” Bow spoke up to which Adora had a soft smile of relief. Even Glimmer could see such valuable intel.

Immediately Adora furrowed her brow, something was off. Especially given recent events, “how’d you escape Gareth’s revolt?” Adora asked, her tone suggested both confusion and a

slight undertone of anger which caused a pang of regret in Shadow Weaver's heart as her mouth dried momentarily.

Shadow Weaver explained as clearly as she could "the fact is that I did not. Months before the portal incident, I escaped the fright zone. I have been living on my own ever since, I-" the calm tide of the sorceress' voice was drowned in the violent storm that was Glimmer's outrage.

"You could have fucking helped us! You bitch! you could have saved my mother!! Hell you could have fucking stopped Apophis from opening up the damn portal in the first place!" Glimmer practically screamed in anger, slamming her fists onto the arm rests of her throne as hot tears rolled down her face.

Shadow Weaver allowed Glimmer's rant to hang in the air for a few moments before she continued. "If I had known about the portal project I would have helped. I'm sorry…" The sorceress' voice wavered a bit as she forced back some tears.

Glimmer rubbed her eyes and Adora went back to comforting her wife. General Juliet of Brightmoon stepped forward, gaining the attention of the two queens. "My queens, we could put Shadow Weaver into a secure room, as we are still building the dungeon. Until you two can come to a decision of course." She suggested, occasionally looking at Weaver who remained kneeling.

Adora held Glimmer close, who was shuddering from rage and sadness. All the warrior queen could do was offer a gentle nod of

agreement. Glimmer was too caught up in her emotions to make the decision.

Before the guards could move towards her, Shadow Weaver stood up and allowed herself to be escorted out of the throne room. Going down several flights of stairs, and thus several floors of the castle, they reach the Larder which even down here in the dank darkness still had the wonderful aesthetic of Brightmoon, though made haunting with gently glowing magelight lamps.

The sounds of construction were heard as the dungeon was being made from empty halls that had been originally intended for more peaceful storage but must instead be made for war efforts.

Shadow Weaver was escorted into one of these huge rooms and the door was locked, the magelight flickered to life highlighting the various amounts of Amarand-made cheeses and she sat herself down onto a large wheel of cheese. *fuck she could go for some wine*

In those minutes she began to contemplate if she should go away. It's clear that Glimmer hates her guts, no doubt Adora told stuff about her disastrous attempts at being a mother.

Shadow Weaver rested her chin onto her hands and removed her mask, pinching the bridge of her nose and letting out a small groan. She let go of her nose and stared out into the unanswering darkness, all 3 of her children were leading kingdoms. Catra and Gareth rule over Ziadroth and Adora...well she’s queen of brightmoon.

But now they were going to war with each other. She knew that it would be a monstrous war, one unlike anything else this planet has ever seen. But...she knew that she had to choose one side, she already made her choice coming here.

She would rather help protect those she had wronged than further cause them wrong. The only way to bring this war to an end was with the coalition, she knew that Gareth would be no tyrant...but that was to his own people, many people will die because of him and she couldn't help him bring such death to the scarred world.

After a few more hours, the door's lock shunted open and Shadow Weaver was fast to put her mask back on as Glimmer entered the room, though Shadow Weaver could see Adora and some guards outside the open door. It was obvious that Glimmer being pregnant would be escorted.

Glimmer clasped her hands together and twiddled her thumbs gently. A lot of strong emotions were going through her mind but she put those aside, she insisted to Adora that she wanted to break the news to her.

"Shadow Weaver, I have come to inform you of me and my wife's acceptance of your proposal." Glimmer brought her clasped hands up to her face and breathed deeply. " *however* yoooooou will be under strict supervision until we deem you can be trusted" Glimmer explained to Weaver.

Shadow Weaver chuckled warmly. “How many swears did you have to hold back?”

“Aaaaa metric fuck ton and a shitting half” Glimmer said with a defeated sigh and lowered shoulders.

Shadow Weaver tapped the sides of her cheese wheel seat and moved some locks of hair past her face. “We need to secure our side of the continent. But you will swiftly see that it is a far more difficult task than you can imagine.”

Glimmer gave a warm smile to Shadow Weaver. “Oh I'm sure we can imagine...Kara” she said, calling Shadow Weaver by her true name.

Contrary to popular belief there is more than one continent on Etheria, and Salineans rarely travel beyond the western sea and the Horde have only the most rudimentary knowledge of these lands.

The continent in which the Coalition and Ziadroth, and all its various peoples, call home is known as Uridex. But there are other continents, for Uridex is simply the center of a much larger and beautiful world.

To the East of Uridex, beyond the seas that Ziadroth controls, are the beast-filled lands of Draalsiv. Land of immense swamps and ancient ruined Eternian structures. Where creatures of horror

wander, in ancient times the most advanced natives traveled to Uridex. These were known as the Luzargans, the most well known of their kind is Rogelio.

To the icy north of Uridex, lie the mysterious lands known as Tundreeze, the only whispers of what lives there are known as the Gorikki. Mighty ratfolk barbarians, whose existence have never been recorded outside of the tales of sailors.

To the Southwest of Uridex is the almost tropical paradise of The Iris. Where rumors of treasure and a civilization that uses first ones technology arouse both ambition and horror among those who have been infected with the knowledge of such rumors.

The continents were kept isolated, never allowing the knowledge of each other to exist. Thanks to how the Eternians and the Etherians, in all of their diversities, were ruled by the tyranny of the God Serpents.

In this age those who possess full knowledge of these lands, that Etheria is breathtakingly massive, belong exclusively to pirates and other seabound scoundrels. From all walks of life and all corners of the planet, these seabound marauders are the connections of Etheria that the gods of old feared and never wanted.

Sailing the briney and tropical waters of the southwestern sea was the Spectral Kraken, this immense mobile fortress bears sigils of Krakens upon its black sails and decorated with tendrils and eyes.

Making it resemble more of a creature of the deep than a mighty vessel.

The captain of this vessel awoke from her slumber. Her ruby red eyes adjusted to the flame lit darkness of her cabin, her amazonian body shifted from the bed as her raven black air shifted against her scarred back. Her pointed ears twitched gently in the humid darkness.

The captain absentmindedly rubbed her fangs with her tongue, still as sharp as ever. This was Captain Eveline Kruzer, the only vampire still alive on Etheria. She grumbled as she got out of her bed, the candles illuminating her ivory skin, devoid of any color whatsoever. It was a stormy tropical night which suited her just fine as the sun never liked her.

She put on her clothes, long jacket and placed a lit cigar in her mouth. Grabbing a bottle of blood rum, Eveline shook off the hangover she had the night before, she shifted her ruby eyes to the sleeping vixen woman on the other side of her bed. She mumbled something to herself before pressing the bottle to her lips and taking a deep drink of the smoky red ichor.

It was only then that she became aware of the knocking at her cabin door, she let out a low groan and approached the door to her cabin and swung the door open. “What?” Eveline growled lowly, A member of her crew stood at attention.

The Luzargan crewmate shuddered a bit from the clear annoyance of the captain, she cleared her throat as her purple scales

shuddered in the rain of the storm. “W-wake up call c-c-captain” she said, her big blue eyes looking up at Eveline’s hooded ruby eyes.

Eveline moved the cigar in her mouth a bit before talking “Right, get the duchess on a rowboat back to The Iris, I need to talk to our prisoners down in the brig” Eveline said, jerking a clawed thumb over her shoulder. The crewmate nodded in response to this, though she waited until Eveline stepped away from the door frame before she did anything.

Eveline walked across the deck, her crew composed of the many species known across the planet. Most of them primarily from the wild continent of Draalsiv, many mercenaries from the various violent species serve the various pirate crews of Etheria. Their bloodlust serves them and their seafaring masters well.

Eveline pulled up the collar of her jacket to shield her a bit more from the raging storm, even as her full brim hat blocked some of the rain. Opening a wooden hatch in the floor, Eveline entered the armored innards of her mighty warship.

Immediately in the large hammock-infested crew quarters, many of the lazing crew members snapped to attention as their mighty captain walked past them. She paid them little mind, she had more important matters to attend to.

Deep inside the dark, cold damp innards of this mighty artificial beast lie various compartments needed to ensure the Spectral

Kraken is fully operational. Like the mighty organs of a deep sea beast, each one is specialized for its purposes.

Among these lay the brig, and it is here that extremely valuable intel can be recovered from a special type of prisoner that have become extremely valuable during these dark ages.

Ex-Force Captains.

From when the Horde once existed. These were those who survived the monstrous Crimson Revolution and did not bend the knee to the Emperor and Empress. The mysterious 'Loyalists' have been in hiding since the violent revolt, one of many changes in a world now fearing the new immense Dieselpunk Dominion of Ziadroth as it has awakened with its Emperor's declaration of war.

The kind of war Ziadroth is capable of unleashing terrified the many Pirate Lords and various criminal empires, as the ambitions of this empire will extend beyond Uridex and will no doubt start turning its terrifying gaze upon them, hungry for new territories to subsume into itself.

Eveline did not dread this new Dark Age of Etheria, this so-called *Great War* , in fact she wished to embrace its uncertainty with open arms and a greedy gaze. Uridex is going to erupt in flames and blood, and Eveline wishes to exploit that to her greatest desires.

She spat out her cigar and took a deep swig of her precious blood-alcohol. Moments of intense silence like these almost make her wish for her First Mate. Seahawk was a brash dumb idiot, always prone to igniting the Spectral Kraken on fire, but her beloved warship could withstand it. The singing on the other hand…

"Damn idiot didn't have the guts to be a real captain, even if I practically raised that man" Eveline snarled to the darkness of her mighty vessel as the storm raged outside. A storm like this swallowed Seahawk...a simple rowboat like the one he rode away from Eveline couldn't survive. Even if it was drifting off to Salineas waters…

Eveline slammed the bottom of her drink against the nearest wall, it made a low dull thud in the creaking of her mighty vessel. She made her way to the brig and approached the first cell, pulling out her flintlock, she rattled it against the bars of the cell, waking up the gaggle of prisoners.

"Alright you damn Hordelings, I am not taking any of your damn flak. So listen up and listen well…" Eveline snarled, looking at the defiant eye-patch wearing merfolk in particular. Her tentacled hair was particularly irking the vampiric captain.

"Now given how Ziadroth and the so-called *Coalition* is paying an extremely high bounty for Loyalists such as yourselves, I could just ship you off and let you go...you know die...buuuut" Eveline gave a twisted grin and leaned forward. The dim light of the candles made her eyes glow even more.

“I have a better proposition, you can join my crew...and tell me all about Ziadroth’s Emperor and Empress. Which sounds like a great deal” Eveline then leaned backwards and aimed her pistol directly at the Merfolk’s other eye.

“Now do we have an Accord? Or no?” Eveline finished with a grin that would make even the most vile creatures in hell jealous.

Elsewhere, in the bitterly frozen lands of the Ice Kingdom, a strange distorted portal tears itself open. Screams leak from the portal as corrupted energy seeps into the air like a cancerous stench, a woman cloaked in a large red robe steps forward and out of the portal.

The woman squinted her ruby red eyes across the landscape, scanning for anyone in the vicinity. The woman smiled, revealing large incisors in her mouth as she extended a pale clawed hand and waved the screaming maw of dimensional hell shut.

“Ah, I think I finally found it. They will be so very pleased” she said to herself, in a voice those of both the Coalition and Ziadroth would find extremely familiar. The crimson cloaked woman reached into her pocket and pulled out a strange bat-like mask. “but…I gotta be sure. Can’t make the same mistake fucking twice” she hissed gently before putting the mask over her face.

The woman began making her way south, away from the icy hellscape. “If this is the correct place, then I can’t be late for the fireworks! After all…” the woman turned towards *you* and showed her face to be much like Adora’s but a vampiric visage.

“This will be one hell of a party! Oh dear reader of mine~” Lady

Crimson purred before cackling and walking into the blizzard, vanishing from sight and leaving nothing but the echoes of her laughter in the air.

Chapter 1: Uranium Fever

ARC I

BLOOD ON THE SAND

Chapter 1:

Uranium Fever

To the kingdoms of the Coalition, there was very little that the Crimson Wastes could offer. During the age of the Horde, It was viewed as a wasteland that held no strategic value and Hordak's obsession with Prime had blinded him to what the Crimson Wastes could offer. This lack of interference had made the Crimson Wastes the most lawless land in Etheria.

Where millions upon millions of people live in communities, slavery or in the service of the countless resurgent warlord empires. Lashor ruled the largest warlord empire, dominating vast swathes of the Crimson Wastes, but that all changed when Catra executed Lashor via decapitation by her Sword Whip and the army she had created.

These countless barbarians and criminals from all corners of the wastes became the soldiers of the Crimson Revolution. Indeed that is why the Crimson Revolution was called as such, for it was waged by Gareth's revolutionaries and Crimson Wastelanders. The millions would settle into the Ziadroth and help it become their new home, a warrior empire built by warriors.

This is why Ziadroth grew so rapidly in both population and sheer size. Why it dominates a vast portion of Eastern Uridex is because of the countless Ex-Horde members who Joined Gareth and the Crimson Wastelanders working together and creating this new Norse-inspired Industrial nation.

Now that war had been declared, The largest kingdom that Etheria has ever seen turns its volcanic gaze upon the Crimson Wastes from which its denizens hail from. For the first time in centuries, the Crimson Wastes will be invaded and life will change forever for those who called it home.

Crimson clad warriors in a vast array of crimson clad machines of war and expansion began to swarm into the Crimson Wastes. The warlords who didn't surrender to the Emperor and Empress would find themselves annihilated and sacrificed to the Norse Gods that Ziadroth now worshiped and everything they owned being taken into the possession of Ziadroth.

Massive machines were set up to harvest the resources that the Crimson Wastes were rich in, secrets that denizens of the Wastes had now were known to Ziadroth. Oil, Metals such as Uranium and Titanium, hell even the buried First Ones ruins were being ruthlessly exploited by Ziadroth.

This didn't worry the remaining independent warlords as much as Ziadroth's vow to exterminate Slavery. Slavers of all kinds were slaughtered and butchered, their bodies hung from erected pillars for all to see. The Slaves were more than happy to join Ziadroth

and they make some of the most patriotic and loyal citizens Ziadroth had.

The Coalition were caught by surprise by their foe's sudden and violent expansion into the Crimson Wastes and diplomatically they were caught in a very precarious spot as since they will no doubt fight to keep Ziadroth out of the Crimson Wastes, they would be seen as a faction that supports slavery in doing so.

In order to deal with this inevitable negative perception, Perfuma personally volunteered to lead the Coalition's efforts in the region. It may be out of her element in terms of hostility, but she was the most diplomatically attuned out of the leaders of the Coalition. Emperor Gareth sent forth General Minox to oversee the taming and invasion of the Crimson Wastes after a suitable foothold was established in the Crimson Wastes.

Minox Sunbreaker is a behemoth of a minotaur, a species rarely seen in Uridex but he himself was acquired from slavers by Horde recruiters during Hordak's Reign. Minox' loyalty to the Horde was always debatable, but he was an effective Force Captain and thus was kept as a member of the Horde. Viewing Hordak as a coward and no warrior, in the days leading up to the crimson revolt, he was the first of the Force Captains to join Gareth and Catra's crimson revolution.

Minox was by all means, the perfect representation of Ziadroth itself. An armored titan of wrath and destruction, he quickly picked up Ziadroth's new Norse language and its warrior culture with ease. With two brutal Axes in his hands, he sought to bring the wastes under his master's control, even if that meant brutally bringing the independent communities into compliance.

Far from the frontlines and in the heart of Ziadroth was the great *Castle Elinas* which was made from the original command center from where Hordak ruled. Now the Emperor and Empress ruled from this mighty fortress in the heart of their kingdom. The Empress herself, Catra Elinas, was leaning against the ramparts of a castle wall looking out over her kingdom. A smile of contentedness and pride decorated her face as she let the warm air blow past her fur and hair.

"Hey wildcat!" Came a cheery and happy voice, Catra playfully rolled her eyes and looked over at Scorpia. She teasingly cocked an eyebrow upwards "shouldn't you be working on organizing those battle reports?" She said with a smile, leaning against the rampart gently and tapping a few of her claws against the metallic ramparts.

"Well I finished that stuff and wanted to tell you about it" Scorpia said with a soft smile, Catra looked at Scorpia and now noticed that she was carrying a large packet of reviewed battle reports. Catra maintained her relaxed posture but she seemed to be anticipating something from these reports.

"Well we figured out who the commander of the rebel forces in the crimson wastes is." Scorpia stated, she noticed Catra's suddenly tense posture but continued to report. "Its not Adora, its erm...Perfuma" Scorpia stated, feeling more relieved upon seeing Catra become more relaxed by it. Scorpia wondered why Catra and Gareth were so worried about Adora's eventual return to the battlefield, but she never asked, mainly to not discomfort her two closest friends.

“Well how’s Minox handling this?” Catra asked, she understood that she and Gareth needed to focus on fine tuning and putting the finishing touches to the military and administrative aspects of Ziadroth. Everything they worked on along with their close friends over the 3 years leading up to the war was great, but there was always room for improvement.

They needed a hammer to bring the wastes and its resources under Ziadroth control, even though Catra viewed Minox as a tad bit overkill compared to their other options, the empress couldn’t help but wonder where to aim said hammer once they succeeded. “So far, the rebels have been keeping their distance but they have engaged several times, they’ve been very bloody and chaotic” Scorpia stated with a nod.

“And any word about the resources being brought to Ziadroth?” Catra asked, they have been receiving the resources but at not a fast enough rate. Especially when they need Uranium or *Hellstone* as Crimson Wastelanders call it.

The green glowing ore is powerful and is used to fuel their city’s massive reactors which brings electricity to every corner of the immense city. As one can imagine, its incredibly valuable and even though they have enough to last the city for the next 100 years, they have to ensure complete control over the resource unless their enemies destroy it.

“Well...Minox seems to be putting a higher priority on ensuring the enemy and the wastelanders are under control...raaaather than protecting our supply lines. Oh and because he’s constantly running about, some of the regions are trying to break away” Scorpia sheepishly said with an awkward shrug. Catra grinded her

teeth a bit, Minox *should* be focusing on both conquest and managing the regions he conquered for Ziadroth.

"How many resources have we lost?" Catra said with an undertone of anger in her voice, a gentle scraping was heard as she dug her claws into the rampart. Scorpia gulped a bit and tapped the tips of her claws together gently with a very nervous expression on her face.

"Uhm...a quarter. That's how the rebels are hitting us, the supply lines." Scorpia said with a shudder and continued her nervous smile. Catra sighed and ran her hands through her hair and looked at Scorpia. "Have you informed Gareth?" She asked which Scorpia shook her head in response.

"Nope, I came straight to you, mainly because I feel like he would be rather upset and-" Scorpia was cut off by Catra's exasperation. "Scorpia, this stuff is rather important! We aren't Hordak! We aren't Weaver! We won't hurt you for this! Its been 3 years since we began running this stuff." Catra said, trying to carefully keep her voice from being too angry but failing somewhat.

"Ye-yeah but the worst we had to deal with are those crimelords in the undercity but this is...different. It's war and…" Scorpia's voice trailed off as Catra patted her shoulder and exhaled, though the empress did give a warm smile.

"It's okay Scorpia. I'll go tell Gareth, you go take a break for a bit" Catra said with a smile. Scorpia nodded before watching Catra walk off. Catra heard the clacking of her boots against the metal

floor, and various soldiers snapped salutes to her as she made her way to the royal chambers.

The Royal Chambers are Catra and Gareth’s private room. Their little private sanctuary from the hardships of running their kingdom and managing the war. It's pretty big, being the size of a large apartment with its own private fireplace, bedroom and among other aspects that make things comfortable.

Gareth sat on the couch by the fireplace in casual clothing and reading a book, when Catra opened the door, the emperor’s head shot up. “Oh hey Kit Kat, how are you doing?” He asked with a small smile. Catra sighed a bit “ohhh...Scorpia told me that Minox is more focused on getting the people of the wastes under control than trying to ensure our foothold is there, hell he’s not even doing a good job at that...i mean the rebels are striking supply lines” she said as she walked towards the couch, removed her crown and collapsed on the couch next to Gareth.

The Empress leaned onto Gareth and gently closed her eyes, exhaling gently. Gareth put his arm around her and placed the book he was reading down, stroking her hair a bit. Catra purred gently, “I guess even our kingdom is bound to have a few accidents when we started this war...but not this soon.” She said gently she then looked into his emerald eyes, feeling like she could get lost in them.

“I guess we should send a message to Minox.” Gareth said but Catra shook her head. She exhaled gently through her nose and looked at him, the crackling fireplace only adding more to the intimate moment they were having.

“What are the chances the guy checks that digital email stuff Entrapta’s set up? Clearly Minox isn’t doing his part fully...He needs an in person visitation from the emperor.” Catra said with a small smirk, gently tracing a claw across his chest.

Gareth chuckled and stroked her furry cheek. “I’ll be back Kit Kat, at most I think i’ll take a week to sort things out” He explained to his beloved empress, giving a kiss right on her nose. Catra gently chuckled and gave him a gentle kiss on the lips “Kick some ass for me, i’ll make sure the kingdom is running well~” she said gently, her smile turned a bit lustful as her tail moved.

Catra leaned forward as she bit her lip gently “but before you go out there my brave husband” her voice trailed off as she slowly tugged at his collar. Gareth blushed and smiled, Catra leaned forward and whispered into his ear “I want you to fuck the everloving shit out of me”

And thus the emperor and empress made intense and passionate love which is something the two did *every single night* . Much to Entrapta’s surprise, there hasn’t been a pregnancy yet.

The following couple of days was preparation for deployment. General Scorpia is to join the Emperor in this operation to permanently establish Ziadroth in the Crimson Wastes, as the right hand of the Emperor must always do. This is a duty Scorpia excels in as well as enjoys, to beside her greatest friends in a kingdom she helped build.

Upon late summer of the year 2289, The Emperor and the 5th Ziadrothan Legion are deployed into the crimson waste to bring Minox back on track and to finalize their presence in the regions they have conquered but not have fully brought into compliance.

The massive Landships are immense titanic tanks, whose massive treads can crush forests and grind rocks into dust. Each Landship is capable of carrying 100,000 troops along with everything from weapons, ammo, supplies and even vehicles. Each Legion has 5 Landships, capable of carrying the entire legion.

The Crimson waste will see the might of 2 entire legions, a massive escalation in the opening acts of the Great War. A pattern of bloodshed that will be seen for a long time to come. Within one of these Landships, Gareth and Scorpia were present. In their full combat equipment of course.

With his powerful triple-barrel shotgun and the infamous greataxe known as Bloodbane in addition to his powerful crimson armor. Gareth was calibrating his armblade, mounted to the side of his left gauntlet, he experimented with it.

The blade extending and retracting from its slot with a fearsome metallic scrape, it was a great backup weapon though it had yet to taste enemy blood unlike his other weapons.

The intense rumbling of the Landship he was on made even common objects noticeably rattle upon the bolted down furniture, Gareth had to admit it took some getting used to though he was

impressed that even the light fixtures did not sway and were secure in their place.

Scorpia entered the command cabin of the emperor carrying a tray of food. It was not a ration bar, no Ziadrothan has had a Ration Bar. Those wretched blobs of gods-knows-what are something that only the former horde members remember, now they have actual food. Roasted meats, soups and other stuff created from fresh ingredients harvested from their various in-door farms within the great city.

While, of course, the soldiers on the field have to use canned variants. Even the canned food was far superior in flavor and enjoyability than anything the Horde produced in what was laughingably called food.

With some bonebread loafs, two bowls of hearty potato and steak soup, and of course large ice cold fizzy drink cans. There was a good soldier's meal for both Scorpia and Gareth. Fizzy Drinks, or *Sodas* as Entrapta called them, are popular non-alcoholic drinks among Ziadrothans with Mead being the popular alcoholic drink.

Ziadrothan soda is essentially a sweetened, carbonated and non-alcoholic variant of Ziadrothan mead. Despite these properties, it's extremely popular amongst Ziadrothans, especially the younger members.

"Here you go boss! Fresh out of the cafeteria! Just like our awesome warriors!" Scorpia said as she set the tray down and used plates in the cabin to help the two not eat on the same tray.

Gareth retracted his blade and sat across from Scorpia. Scorpia hummed happily as she utilized her special utensils to eat the food.

"So, what do you think the situation is gonna be like?" Gareth asked Scorpia while taking a bite from the spherical loaf of bonebread, chewing it between his sharp teeth.

A curious trait he possessed that came from his genetic lineage, everyone assumed it was from his so-called *human* species but a quick read from the old Weaver archives suggests his extended incisors are from the unknown aspect of his heritage, his birth father's species.

Though Gareth rarely cared about such a matter. It was just another genetic anomaly from a species unknown to the universe, much like the bile sac attached to his heart that allows him to cast magic. With Apophis' crystal fused to his chest, Gareth had two sources from which to cast magic from, though these days he very much prefers the bile sac.

"Oh! Well, uhhh...to be honest I think it's gonna be a mess! Like stuff is everywhere and no organization! I mean everyone's doing good fighting but barely anyone's making sure things aren't falling apart! It's gonna be awful!" Scorpia said, using her arms to gesture a suggested size of the chaotic mess they were gonna get into.

Gareth leaned back in his chair and nodded, finishing the bonebread loaf to then drink from his soda. He then leaned

forward and rested his chin on one of his clawed gauntlet-wearing hands. “I am not sure if I should have sent Minox out there alone, he’s only doing half his job” Gareth mused, tapping his index and middle finger against the stubble of his cheek.

Scorpia shrugged and ate some of the soup, blowing on the steaming portions before putting it in her mouth. The fatty and buttery meat with the thick potatoes in the gravy-like broth brought a giddy smile to her cheeks. Scorpia knew that she could never go back to those stupid ration bars every time she had a meal in Ziadroth, she just loved it.

“Well don’t beat yourself up boss! It's not your fault that Minox isn’t doing his job, it's clearly...well Minox’s fault!” Scorpia said with a smile before scooping another few portions of the delicious soup into her mouth and chewed it up.

Gareth nodded “true, but he is gonna have to be reprimanded. Damn bastard’s taking us away from home, having to deal with his bullshit” Gareth growled lowly, even out here he’s thinking about his family and friends back home.

Scorpia frowned a bit but she understood. Gareth’s always been like this, so used to being the shield for his small group of friends and family that even now he feels like he should be the one doing it. Even though they got lots of guys who can do that for them.

“Boss, it’ll be okay. Besides we’ll be back in Ziadroth before you know it!”

Chapter 2: Assault on Fort Fearfang

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Assault on Fort Fearfang

Fort Fearfang, the former fortress that Lashor once called home, is now the immense symbol of military might that Ziadroth represents and now has its influence over the Crimson Wastes. Perhaps as a show of its brutality, the bones of Lashor and his closest followers who had died with him had been integrated into the very command center of this mighty fortress.

It is here that Minox operates from, leading the efforts to unify the Crimson wastes under Ziadroth rule. However, the announcement of the emperor and another legion coming to the Fort has by all means attracted his attention and when he arrived at Fort Fearfang, the emperor and his right hand were already present.

The crimson spiked armor of the Ziadrothan warriors along with their skull-faceplates and golden colored eye-lenses gave them the appearances of demons, this was only exemplified by their fearsome rifles which were bulky and sported large drum mags and fearsome looking bayonets. With an Axe on their hips, they were a fearsome sight to see, but with the sheer numbers that Gareth brought that heavily populated the Fort...it looked like hell split open and discharged its legions.

The command center was a buzzing hive of activity as red screens illuminate the dimly lit room. Gareth furrowed his brow as he sat

at the main command console and gently scrolled through report after report. He hadn't changed out of his combat armor since he arrived at the fort which worried Scorpia somewhat...was he expecting Minox to fight?

Minox's sudden arrival into the command center had surprised Scorpia as she suddenly stood up straight. Gareth stood up as well and glared somewhat at Minox, despite the minotaur being much taller than him, that slight scowl had the general worried.

"Two...Things...I had specifically asked you to do two things. Unite the Crimson Wastes AND make sure that Ziadroth is getting their supplies" Gareth said with a slight growl and clenching his fists, he began to approach Minox as his armblade fully extended with a loud metallic shing.

"But you are only fulfilling only one of your obligations and barely accomplishing the second." Gareth said angrily gritting his teeth as he did so. His eyes were locked directly into Minox's eyes.

"I had administrators-" Minox barely fulfilled his sentence before Gareth yelled at him again. "You are supposed to make sure THOSE admins are doing their job every now and then! Good fucking gods in valhalla, now I have to go all the way from Ziadroth to make sure the job is done well!" Gareth shouted at Minox.

Minox kneeled to Gareth. "My emperor, I swear to you, I didn't mean to impede upon your duties with my incompetence. Please forgive me, this will not happen again" Minox begged Gareth,

looking down upon the Emperor's crimson boots though Gareth did not make a move.

"We are going to work together to fix this damn mess. You won't die, but I will make sure that this incompetence doesn't infect the rest of my damn empire. Do I make myself clear General?" Gareth whispered as he pressed the tip of his armblade into Minox's chest, threatening to break the skin open.

Minox nodded "y-yes my Emperor" he stated before Gareth sheathed his armblade and stepped back. "Good, very good" Gareth stated before he stepped back. Scorpia approached Gareth and Minox.

"So uhh, Boss...I assume we're gonna see this through personally?" Scorpia said, already figuring out her friend's motives to which Gareth nodded and clasped a hand upon her shoulder. "We sure are Scorps. But it's been a long trip and I'm going to rest a bit. I think you should too" Gareth said with an exasperated sigh and a stroking of his chin. Something that he does when he is in deep thought or in stress, Scorpia could possibly guess he is in both such states.

Gareth slowly slid his hand off of Scorpia and made his way to the imperial quarters. Where the Emperor and Empress, or the soon-to-be-named Regional Governor, stays when they arrive into the region.

Gareth entered the chambers and had some robotic servants remove his armor and place it on an appropriate mantle. The

young Emperor threw on a basic black shirt and brown pants before going over to the stocked fridge. Clearly it was stocked before the emperor's arrival with a variety of foods and drinks.

Back at home, he'd have his favorite meal. A large fatty steak fried in bone marrow and served with a side of crispy potato wedges with a large helping of berry flavored Ziadroth Soda. Obviously he can't have that here, so instead he pulled out a few fried chicken drumsticks and a cold Ziadroth Soda bottle. They really need to figure out a new name for that product aside from just *Ziadroth Soda* .

Gareth walked over to the dining table with his food, only to notice that there were already lit candles set on the table. Gareth gently placed his food on the counter and pulled out his shotgun, pulling back the three hammers. His eyes darted around the room, trying to find the intruder in question.

"Hello Gareth" came the voice of Shadow Weaver in a dark corner and the shape of his maternal figure. Gareth immediately aimed the shotgun towards the corner and was about to pull the trigger when the figure raised her hands.

"Oh! Woah! Okay! Don't shoot!" The figure said before shifting into Double Trouble. Gareth recognized the changeling from the princess prom years ago and lowered his shotgun. The emperor tilted his head to the side as he tried to remember Double Trouble's name, he wasn't good at remembering names after only meeting them once ages ago.

“Hey Cutie uhh...it's me Double Trouble! Remember from the princess prom!” Double Trouble said with a cute smile to which Gareth tapped his chin before he remembered the name and connected the dots together.

“Oh yeah! We met and- did you just call me cutie?” Gareth said with a raised eyebrow “uhm, my name’s Gareth.” He said confused by what Double Trouble had called him. This only made the reptilian shapeshifter chuckle and leaned against the nearest wall.

“That’s what I like about you Gareth. You have such a fiery emotion! You’d kill it as an actor, you got the whole himbo potential just lined right up!” Double Trouble said as they walked over to a very confused Gareth.

“Uhm...I guess Himbo is an acting term, aside from wanting to obviously catch up. Any other reason for your unannounced visit? Also how’d you learn Ziadrothan?” Gareth asked while keeping an eye on Double Trouble’s movements the whole time.

“Well I wanted to see the glorious emperor himself! And to ask if you were looking to hire me. I know you are all about that strength stuff, but I am sure you can make a exception as for Ziadrothan, well an actor has their methods after all~” Double Trouble purred and leaned against Gareth with a smirk but Gareth rolled his eyes and gently moved back to distance himself from Double Trouble.

“It's not *just* physical strength. It's what you are best at, your literal strengths. Like your strength could be that you are a great

actor, or that you're really good with technology. Its using what you are best at to overcome what you are not good at. Your strength overcomes your weaknesses" Gareth explained with a small smile and a nod to go with it.

Double Trouble blinked a couple times in surprise, They did not expect that. In fact, they thought Ziadroth was all a bunch of barbarians. But this was a bit unexpected, not they were complaining about it. They could totally work with it.

"Well that sounds...rather nice. But still, I am interested in working with you Emperor Gareth. So what do you say?" Double Trouble inquired with a small smirk dancing across their lips as they leaned forward.

Gareth crossed his arms and furrowed his brow. "Well you are gonna have to prove yourself" the emperor of Ziadroth said, not exactly trusting them as he was worried that the coalition got to them first before they came here to the fort.

Suddenly the lights turned red and alarms began to blare all across the Fort. Gareth quickly made a dash to put his armor on and grab the rest of his weaponry. Double Trouble heard the mad dash of boots outside the room, it took them a moment to realize that the Coalition was attacking the Fort.

"We'll talk later" Gareth said with a small hint of excitement in his voice, it had been so long since he tasted the glory of battle. The Emperor rushed out of the room, Scorpia quickly joined his side as

the warriors began to shout orders and Ziadrothan war chants began to ring across the fort.

Gazing upon the enemy outside, it was more than the Coalition, it was the various warbands that had allied themselves with the Coalition. It was a sizable army, even as Ziadrothan artillery cannons rocked the ground and their shells impacted the ground and ripped craters into the very sands and the enemy themselves.

Gareth charged forward, the enemy was already being met on the battlefield by Ziadrothan warriors charging out of the fort and opening fire at the enemy. Many would be hit by arrows, those arrows that hit them in the eyes or other unarmored areas would see those very warriors fall and not get up.

By the time Gareth and Scorpia got to the gates, the enemy was already trying to scale the walls and they were being aided by magical plants. Gareth already knew who was leading the army, he tilted his head until he cracked his neck before he brought Bloodbane down onto an unfortunate soldier, splitting them apart from the head and down into the torso.

Gareth's armblade extended and he slashed open the throat of a Plumeran soldier that attempted to kill him from behind. The warm crimson spray splattered against Gareth's face, but the Emperor was unfazed as he ripped Bloodbane from the corpse of the other soldier he had just bisected.

Gripping his greataxe in both hands, its blades engulfed in magical flame, he carved through squads of soldiers as his own warriors

opened fire with their mighty rifles, shouting in the tongue of Ziadroth as they did so. Scorpia grabbed two Coalition soldiers by the neck and slammed them into the ground with such force that the very ground cracked and exploded.

Scorpia let out a soft exhale before closing her claws, decapitating the two soldiers and spraying blood all over her claws. She used her strength and stinger to shatter armor and ensure that the enemy fell with ease. Scorpia was no stranger to violence, she was a warrior after all.

Both Scorpia and Gareth charged into the battlefield, where the ruins of coalition seige engines and blood of both Ziadroth and the Coalition stained the sands in both dark and crimson hues. For indeed that is why they call it the crimson wastes, for all the blood that had been shed upon these dunes.

Gareth unholstered his shotgun and let all 3 barrels roar at once, reducing a squad of soldiers into a mist of viscera and blood. Gareth flicked the shotgun, letting the shotgun shells fly out of the barrels before he swiftly reloaded it. Gareth swiftly headbutted another coalition soldier who stumbled backwards and fell onto their backside. Gareth holstered his shotgun before bringing Bloodbane down on the enemy with both of his hands, splitting open the stomach of the soldier.

Suddenly the ground shook, even audible in the midst of the chaotic battlefield that stunk of death and ashes, and huge spiked roots lunged forward at the Emperor. Gareth sliced a few roots with Bloodbane but they kept coming at him, he would see from the corner of his eye that there were other warriors being killed by the roots.

The Emperor suddenly felt the roots wrap around his arms and he was forced to his knees, he could hear the defiant brays of Minox somewhere in the distance. The Emperor felt his arms being pulled behind him as he gazed upon Perfuma and a few other floramancers. Gareth snarled angrily as his eyes locked at the queen of Plumera.

“We have you Emperor, stand down and leave the wastes” Perfuma declared in Etherian, trying her best to be as threatening as she could. Gareth’s response was in the tongue of Ziadroth. “Ég mun aldrei gefast upp. Ég mun aldrei hætta. En þér er alveg sama um það, þú óskar aðeins eftir friðsamlegri lausn. en hlutirnir eru ekki svo einfaldir... leyfðu mér að sýna þér stríðslogana. 1 ”

Perfuma and her floramancers were completely taken back. They did not understand what he had said, This was the language barrier between Ziadroth and The Coalition, Perfuma would have assumed that at least Gareth would address her in Etherian but she was not expecting this.

Gareth grinned and opened his mouth, drawing a circle with his tongue. A ring of orange light lit up in his mouth before he clenched his mouth, jets of magical flame shot out from the gaps of his teeth before unleashing a vast blast of magical fire. Many of the floramancers were caught in the flames, screeching in pain and agony.

The plumeran general, the only floramancer to not get burnt, fell onto his back and completely lost his mind in fear. Perfuma was only able to merely dodge the flames and use whatever plants she

could to shield herself. Gareth broke free of the roots and brought his axe in a full cleave, severing the burning floramancers from their legs.

Gareth glared at Perfuma from where he was standing, blood dripped from his axe as smoke hung onto his breath. Gareth's glare was like the stare of a demon, and Perfuma could feel her soul being searched. Perfuma ran away in fear, declaring a full retreat in the Etherian tongue.

Gareth looked at the Plumeran General who was completely locked in fear. Gareth grinned from ear to ear, an opportunity to learn intel no doubt. Gareth gestured to Scorpia "Scorps, can you lock him up please" Gareth said with an excited grin to which Scorpia obeyed and grabbed the screaming plumeran general.

Gareth then turned around and saw Double Trouble looking at him. The emperor wasn't sure how long they were standing there for but it didn't matter, an opportunity for both of them presented itself in full. Gareth maintained his eager grin, he crossed his arms and leaned forward. "I think I found out the perfect way to prove yourself Double Trouble" Gareth said happily.

Double trouble raised an eyebrow as they wondered what that could be. "Sooo what would it be?" They said as they sat on a pile of coalition bodies, making sure it was also the cleanest part of the pile. They gazed at the falling ashes as the smoke of the battle was forming a thick and ill-scented fog across the battlefield.

“You are going to pose as the plumeran general, find out where Perfuma and the coalition is holed up and allow us to destroy it. You will be paid very handsomely for it” Gareth said with a nod as he leaned on a ruined catapult as the Warriors of Ziadroth marched and scavenged the battlefield for unique equipment they can get their hands on, trophies of war.

Double Trouble grinned from ear to ear, standing up and approaching the emperor, gazing up at the emperor and extending a hand to him. “Its a deal” they said before Gareth shook their hand. Sealing the deal under a smoke choked sky and the sands beneath them soaked with blood and gore.

In the months to come, many Coalition strongholds will fall, coalition warlords will be forced to bend the knee to Ziadroth or be outright destroyed. Perfuma would soon call for reinforcements from the Coalition, and soon Gareth will have a reunion with his sister Adora.

Though this reunion would be as bloody as it would be devastating...

1 Translation: I will never surrender. I will never stop. But you do not care about it, you only wish for a peaceful solution. but things are not that simple...allow me to show you the flames of war.

Chapter 3: War Marches Forward

Chapter 3:

War Marches Forward

Adora stood before the funeral pyre, more soldiers had died in their attempt to stem the tide of Ziadroth. The warmth of its intensity was at risk of burning her face as the embers drifted past her features, she heard the clatter of armor as a soldier of brightmoon approached her, though she did not tear her gaze from the blaze of soldiers that gave their lives in the name of the coalition.

“Your majesty, our soldiers are ready.” The brightmoon soldier maintained a stiff stance, though he was young. Barely an adult, Adora turned her head and could only think of how quickly he would be killed in the field of war and battle. She maintained her silence for a few moments more until she opened her mouth and spoke with the intensity of a warrior that remained unbroken by the horrors of war. “Then we ride.” Adora said as she marched towards an armored Swift Wing.

They received the desperate message from Perfuma, diplomacy and defenses were not working. Many of the crimson wastelanders did not wish to join, many either having decided to abandon their homes from the oncoming Ziadroth army or simply standing their ground and facing oblivion. Perfuma needed help, and Adora was more than willing to provide it.

Glimmer was in no shape to fight, especially with her bearing their child, so Adora will personally oversee this operation. Adora rolled her neck as the cool Autumn air contrasted sharply from the blazing inferno of the funeral pyre of the honored dead, in fact she was surprised to notice that she had sweat ever so slightly.

The soldiers of Brightmoon were the core of the coalition, their armor had even been adopted by all kingdoms that composed it. Even plumeran soldiers would be seen wearing it. Compared to the machine guns and the artillery of Ziadroth, the Coalition had plenty of magic and blacksmiths who crafted and enchanted the armor compared to the mass produced equipment of Ziadroth produced in vast factories who used no magic in their production.

Each Brightmoon soldier was well trained,especially when compared to their more numerous counterparts in other kingdoms, but they were few and Ziadroth had legions at its disposal. Indeed, it was akin to a meat grinder, especially with this crusade into the crimson wastes. It was the start of the Great War, and already the casualties were stuff only Hordak could dream of.

However, just as before, The Coalition’s ultimate advantage was magic. It's why they were able to stand against Ziadroth and it is why they have been able to deal casualties against Ziadroth. Now all they need is something that can fire as fast as a standard Ziadrothan Assault Rifle...

Much like her Brother’s deployment, there were very little developments. Many of the soldiers were unprepared for the boiling heat of the Crimson Wastes. Unlike the great Landships, the coalition relied on convoys that marched with them, they

lacked refrigeration and thus must rely on heavily salted rations and other heavily preserved foods.

Adora flew overhead on Swift Wind, keeping an eye from the scorching sky to make sure that they weren't ambushed. Small beads of sweat ran down her brow as she looked down from Swift Wind. "How far are we from Perfuma's base of operations?" Adora said to Swift Wind, normally she would pull out a map but she was more invested in making sure Ziadrothans weren't going to attack.

They were incredibly vulnerable, especially with their supplies being minimally guarded. One wrong move and this army would be decimated by the harsh unforgiving environment that would no doubt swallow them whole. Adora shuddered a sigh as she awaited Swift Wind's response. "Well, Huntara said she would meet us halfway there to the City of Slithermaw" Swift wind said in his unwaveringly cheerful voice. "We're almost there at the rally point! So it's gonna be all cool!" Swift Wind said with a happy smile, looking over his shoulder to look at Adora.

Adora looked ahead, seeing the smoldering horizon. Huntara was a name she had not heard in a good while, especially before the portal incident. The former warlord must have allied herself with the Coalition, maybe it was a better alternative to Ziadroth but she couldn't say for certain.

After a few more hours they came across a considerably sized force of Coalition soldiers and allied Crimson Wastelanders. Adora ordered her army to rest up before she got off Swift Wind and approached Huntara with a small courteous bow and a warm smile.

“Huntara, it's nice to see you on our side” Adora said as Huntara sharpened her weapon, she seemed to lack the same courteous attitude but was still respectful given her nod. “Yeah, I wish I could say that we are okay. But Ziadroth is wrecking our asses, Slithermaw is the last truly allied city, if we lose here the Crimson Waste fully belongs to your brother and your sister” Huntara said grimly as she stood up and twirled her spear.

“They aren’t my brother and sister, they are the enemy. I may love them, but they chose their path and I chose mine. It's fairly obvious that they are living with it” Adora said with a rugged sigh. Huntara noticed Adora’s gilded gauntlet but lack of sword, she was about to ask about it when Adora spoke up.

“Yeah I learned how to change the sword into a gauntlet, it helps me from being disarmed which is definitely going to happen if we get into an ambush” Adora explained, prompting Huntara to nod and give a gentle thumbs up in response.

“Clever” was all Huntara said before she grabbed a large bag which Adora assumed was Huntara’s personal bag. The other Coalition soldiers under Huntara’s command, many of them being Plumerans, began to pack up. “Come on your majesty, Slithermaw is waiting for us.” Huntara said, nodding to the direction north of them.

Much like Lashor’s old fortress, which is now under the control of Ziadroth, Slithermaw is an immense sandstone city which sports a massive stone ceiling, making the massive city covered by a

mighty dome built upon large walls. It's probably why many of those within could live very comfortably.

Since joining the Coalition, the city now has a heavy presence of armored Coalition soldiers. Many of which were injured from the combat that has constantly battered them around the Wastes, now as the last truly Coalition aligned city, if this city falls then Ziadroth would have effective rule over the vast region and their only nuisance would be possible warlords establishing fringe empires.

Adora was in a grim train of thought when a familiar voice snapped her out of it. “Queen Adora!” Perfuma said as she ran up to Adora and gave her as big of a hug as she could muster. Adora smiled somewhat. Her train of thought was disrupted for right now.

“It's so good to see you, I am so glad you brought reinforcements. We definitely need them. Please, you and Huntara come with me into the war room.” Perfuma explained as Adora’s army was unpacking various supplies from the caravans they brought along.

The *war room* was simply the mayor of Slithermaw’s personal manor. And more specifically his Game room. Adora and Huntara stood around a large round stone table with a Plumeran general and Perfuma herself. Perfuma took a deep breath before placing a variety of maps and other pieces of intelligence. The maps were marked with a staggering amount of red with very little blue.

“Minox had been conquering large swathes of territory but only building the most basic of infrastructure and since the whole point of the crimson wastes is to ensure that Ziadroth has constant supplies in both resources and manpower. We had been attacking his barely guarded convoys that were going to Ziadroth. Unfortunately that had been disrupted heavily…” Perfuma explained looking at Adora with an uncharacteristically grim look.

“The Emperor had arrived with *another* legion. We are now facing two legions and furthermore it looks like the only reason they haven’t pushed even further forward is because of one simple reason. They were busy ensuring that everything was developed.” Perfuma explained entirely, the news that Gareth had arrived into the crimson waste was a very large surprise to Adora.

Adora had not seen her brother in 3 years, and now it's more than likely that the two will be reunited in the fierce flames of combat. No doubt that will result in some severe bloodshed, Adora clenched her fists and slammed one of them against the war table.

“DAMMIT!” Adora yelled angrily as Perfuma flinched somewhat while Huntara had no reaction whatsoever to this. She looked at Perfuma with eyes of anger “have you been trying to stop this?” Adora said lowly, she knew Gareth would throw everything he had at Slithermaw once everything was done. He was brutal like that, the typical barbarian strategy, but damn does it work for Ziadroth.

“You traveled along the distant border, it's a blood soaked warzone across the rest of the crimson waste. Battles are erupting constantly and people are dying, it's a goddamn meat grinder...and Ziadroth’s the grinder” Huntara spoke up before

shaking her head. “I’ve never seen anything like it, even when I was in the horde, but no doubt that once Gareth’s done he is coming for the city.” Huntara said but Perfuma shook her head.

“We have been coercing remaining independent and allied warlords into attacking Ziadroth controlled cities and settlements while we have been sabotaging as much as we can. No doubt that we can hold back his progress for a week at least!” Perfuma explained with a gentle voice, her defensive strategy was good in concept but against an offensive juggernaut like Ziadroth would take a much more defiant defense than what Perfuma had going. Something both Huntara and Adora knew.

Adora was quiet for a few moments more, looking at the long list of warlords that had joined the Coalition, much of their names have been crossed out in red. Indicating they had been killed in battle which was not a good sign. “When did he join the fight? Gareth that is” Adora questioned, already trying to formulate a battle strategy within her mind.

Perfuma tapped her chin “he joined the battle a couple months ago. Since then he must have either taken command or given Minox a major verbal beating because Minox has completely changed his strategy and has been at Gareth’s beck and call.” She said with a small shake of her head, Perfuma looked at her general who nodded gently.

“My princess, perhaps we should go over defense plans soon? Like for the walls of the city?” The plumeran general stated to which Perfuma nodded and sighed. “I really made a mess of things huh?” She mused grimly.

Adora shook her head “no, you did the best you could. I’m sorry for yelling earlier, But now we must prepare for the Emperor throwing all he’s got at us.” She stated with an immense intense aura of courage, she rolled her shoulders and Huntara nodded.

“Gather the troops and the citizens, I plan on addressing them” Adora said, Huntara already marched off as the Plumeran general nodded. “I gotcha!” Perfuma said as she and Adora ran off.

The Plumeran General walked off in another direction, entering a dark alleyway behind the governor’s mansion and entering a small windowless shack. The general locked the door and pulled out a Ziadroth Video tablet before he shifted into a androgenyous reptilian humanoid. A member of the Changeling species, the figure turned on the video tablet.

“This is Double Trouble contacting emperor cutie, do you respond?” They said with a soft purr in their force before the call was answered. Gareth was out of his combat armor and wearing a basic black shirt and red pants, his green eyes had the gleam of ambition and there was a slight tone of annoyance in his voice as he spoke.

“Told you not to call me that DT. What new information have you acquired?” Gareth said adjusting his seat on his bed, he had Double Trouble replace the Plumeran general as the shapeshifter had shown interest in joining and it was Gareth’s way of having them prove themselves.

“Well your sister is here in Slithermaw, just as I expected” Double Trouble chuckled and cocked an eyebrow. Seeing Gareth’s frustrated reaction and sigh was definitely worth it. “Adora huh? Well this complicates things, I thought the Coalition would have sent someone like Bow…” Gareth said, stroking his chin.

“So boss, what do you want me to do?” Double Trouble said with a small biting of their lips, Gareth rolled his eyes before answering them. “Simple, relay all of their information to me and then run like hell when we arrive. I am going to invade way ahead of schedule” Gareth said with a low growl to which Double Trouble simply smiled.

“I would suggest that you keep your impulsiveness down a bit cutie, because one day that fire is going to burn you one day” Double Trouble teased to which Gareth rolled his neck gently and grunted in acknowledgement.

“Your warning is noted DT, but you have proved to me you can be trusted. I’ll make sure you are properly paid for” Gareth said gently to which Double Trouble winked and grinned. “Thanks cutie!~” they said before ending the call.

This is gonna be one hell of an assault.

Adora saw the large force of soldiers standing in lines, all awaiting her command and the disorganized citizens looking up to her for guidance and hope. Adora clenched her fists a couple times before she tapped into the magical voice amplifier runes to test them.

Adora closed her eyes and imagined Glimmer and Bow standing by her side before the blonde warrior opened her eyes and began to speak to the crowd before her. Adora hoped that her voice will inspire the populace and help them for the dark times that are so very close.

"People of the Coalition. It was in the spring that Gareth declared his war to the world and now it has been months later. I promised the coalition that we would drive back Ziadroth and its warriors. We certainly will do that, so far Ziadroth had been a flood but you know what stops Floods? Mountains. Slithermaw and the Coalition are a mountain. It is strong, it is solid and it moves for no one. In one week's time, Ziadroth will unleash its forces upon us. Lead by its emperor himself, he seeks to destroy this city and I say no. Let them break their backs upon the fucking mountain!!!" Adora yelled at the top of her lungs as the coalition and the citizens cheered wildly.

Huntara watched Adora deactivate the speaker runes before watching her approach. "Helluva speech Queen Adora." Huntara said, though she knew what Adora said may not hold up. She had seen what Ziadroth had done to mountains, they tear into them and take anything of value before they leave the hollowed husk to rot.

"It has to be a good speech, otherwise they won't have the additional strength to fight" Adora said before looking at Plumera who gently stroked her own hair. It seemed everyone in the room knew what was going to happen...annihilation was coming. Hell's coming with Gareth, and it's unknown how well they will hold the line.

Adora quietly damned every Warlord who had joined Ziadroth and those that had refused to aid them in their hour of need. Adora tapped the bright blue jewel on her gauntlet to calm her nerves. “I suggest you get some sleep, both of you had a long trip and you should rest up” Perfuma said with a gentle nod. Huntara made no argument but Adora didn’t respond at first.

“It's been 3 years since we first looked each other in the eye. This will be my first battle with Ziadroth. I feel like this battle will determine the course of the war for years and years to come. It will set the standard for chaos and bloodshed.” Adora grimly mused, looking out the window over a dark city that rarely saw the sun thanks to its immense ceiling.

Perfuma blinked in surprise, it was one hell of a prediction, a grim and dark one. “You do not know that Adora, you truly do not. Please rest okay?” Perfuma stood aside for Adora to walk past her. Perfuma gently closed the door and shuddered as the images of her botched assault months ago flash through her head.

The screams, the war chants, the gunfire and the thundering artillery. The hatred in Gareth’s eyes as he cleaved through soldiers with utter ease. His close friend Scorpia dealt equal amounts of devastation. Perfuma quickly assembled a variety of incense and began to burn them to try and calm her nerves.

She could feel an oppressive darkness upon her, and she couldn’t help but wonder how so many others could handle it. It felt like thorny tendrils threatening to strangle her to death. Perfuma let

out a choking sob as she tried to contend with the screams of the dead in her head.

Adora walked into a barely lit part of the local manor when she stopped in her tracks and tried to make out what she saw. A woman in crimson robes wearing a strange bat-like mask and a large red hood was leaning on a pillar. Adora quickly turned her gauntlet into a sword as the woman in crimson stopped leaning and made a slow clapping.

Before Adora could take an action, the woman in Crimson cackled before vanishing in a flash of bright red smoke. Adora felt her blood get cold, for the woman laughed in *her own fucking voice.*

"What the fuck…." Adora said before she realized that she hadn't had proper sleep for days, she went to bed. Believing it to be a hallucination...but she wasn't truly sure. Adora laid down on the bed she had been provided and gazed up at the ceiling for a few moments.

"Traya...that's a good name for her" Adora said to herself, thinking of her daughter's name, provided if she became a mother to a daughter of course...

Chapter 4: Rumbling of the Coming Storm

Chapter 4:

Rumbling of the Coming Storm

Adora woke up in the surprisingly cold hours of the day. Before the sun even had come up over the Horizon, the city folk were surprisingly calm and many even went about their day. It seems that Adora had kept things calm but the latest She-Ra still couldn't keep down the palpable sense of dread that permeated her soul and she truly did wonder if everyone felt the dread the same way.

Coalition soldiers were organizing training exercises wherever the mayor allowed them to. Adora sighed to herself as she dressed up in her old casual outfit. she couldn't trust that fat bastard as far as she could throw him and she could reckon she could toss him to the moon. She examined the horde shirt in her hands, she had worn it for so long that it almost felt like a second skin...well that changed when she became queen.

But this was no place to wear her typical white robe and let her hair down. She rubbed a thumb against the bright red sigil of the Horde. It always reminded her of an eyeball surrounded by horrid bat wings. Once a sigil so widely feared, now it seems like everyone has forgotten what the Horde even was. Adora slipped the shirt on and then she slipped on her armor reinforcements including armored shoulderpads.

They always gave her jacket an edged appearance and she couldn't think if it made her impressive or plain ridiculous. But it

saved her body more times that she could think of. She grabbed her sword and spinned it in her grasp before transmogrifying into a gauntlet. “Alright, just keep calm, watch out for spies and...try to keep spirits up” she said to herself, doing a few finger guns before walking out of her quarters.

Adora walked amongst the citizens who gave her bows and even a few gifts, she awkwardly turned down the gifts, she wasn’t sure they would even last during the siege which was inevitable. The city slowly became a buzzing metropolis once again, it was almost terrifying how many people lived in the Crimson Waste...and it shocked Adora seeing a place almost crowded.

It was going to be a nightmare to get them all to run or evacuate. Adora shook her head trying to keep thoughts of war out of her head for just a bit longer. Adora’s goal was simple: spend the next few days personally mapping out the entire domed city to ensure the troopers are utilized to their maximum potential so that the defense is effective.

They were effectively a wall holding back an apocalyptic storm. Adora sighed as she made her way towards the northern wall which faced the vast scarlet desert and it will be where the forces of Ziadroth will approach from. After a few hours of walking through crowds and trying to survey stuff, Adora felt like things could be done easier if she used Swift Wind.

But she felt that would be the wrong message. They do not abuse power, they do not take what they please, they are honorable and they are supposed to be good. It was not a good image that the Coalition said they would openly support the independence of the warlords, sure it was good in theory...but they didn’t do nearly as

much research as they did before they realized they enslaved people in the Crimson Wastes.

Though to be fair, they had so little time to effectively rally and give out a response to their citizens because Ziadroth swarming the Crimson Wastes was something they were not prepared for. They were so certain Ziadroth would attack them head on that all of their resources were sunk into setting defenses up and forts across their borders which made for a formidable defense.

So they were at a disadvantage during the entirety of these battles in the Crimson Wastes even before they even deployed the first wave. Ziadroth took those disadvantages and ran with them all the way to the finish line. Slithermaw must be the final bastion the coalition must hold...even as the might of Ziadroth comes barrelling down upon them.

Adora snapped out of her train of thought when she approached the northern wall, she must have been deep in her thoughts because it was well over a 4 hour walk and her legs were rather worn, not killing her but worn. She made sure she was doing well in cardio while doing her duties managing Brightmoon. Adora felt her boots grind against the dusty gravel and she shoved her hands in her pockets as she approached the very large guard house.

Adora heard strange grinding noises and looked up above to see a rail system overhead with large transports, she felt her shoulders sag and she slapped the top of her head. *Yep, a city this massive needs some basic form of transit* . She wished she had remembered that stuff. Ah well, live and learn. The past adora would have been in a poor and bitter mood over such a simple

mistake, but Adora simply shrugged it off and entered the guard house.

"Queen Adora Arcanis present!" Said a Coalition soldier and all the other soldiers stood at attention. Adora had adopted Glimmer's surname when they married, it always struck her how she didn't have a surname and neither did Catra...only Gareth did but that was because Gareth's birth mother told Shadow Weaver what that was. One of many bits of info that Weaver shared with Adora.

Adora nodded and stood in front of them with her arms behind her back. "Soldiers of the northern Garrison! How are our defenses?" She asked the Officer amongst the soldiers. She saluted Adora, her crimson hair contrasted with her bronze-tinted skin and shiny yellow eyes.

"Sergeant Cithria Goldeneye of Brightmoon! The defenses are surprising. It seems Slithermaw is no stranger to raiders, they have multiple ballistas and even a few heavy metal catapults!!" The young sergeant said excitedly all while maintaining a saluting stance.

"Yeah but this won't be a few meager raiding parties...no this will be a completely different kind of attack. Do any of these weapons look like they can puncture armor?" Adora asked, but before Cithria could respond Adora leaned forward "any that can puncture *tank armor* "

Cithria leaned backwards on her heels as a few nervous beads of sweat rolled down her cheeks and down her forehead. She had to

admit that she honestly didn’t know how effective these weapons were, especially when they faced a metric ton of enemies. She was fresh from Brightmoon, that much was obvious, clearly of a higher house given how she was able to rapidly ascend to an officer.

“No…no, not that I know of…” Cithria stated with a stammer as her eyes darted from side to side, as if begging her comrades to jump in to tell Adora otherwise. But no one would dare try to oppose the Queen, especially one so well versed in combat. Adora leaned back and sighed, pinching the bridge of her nose as she did so.

These poor soldiers are about to get a very bloody introduction to real combat soon, there’s no telling how well they will hold up. Thoughts like that floated past Adora’s thoughts, She hated how cynical those thoughts can become given the circumstances of this war. Adora then focused back on the situation. “Alright we'll make sure to get new bladed tips for the ballistas aaaaand we will need to make some heavier ammunition for the catapults, I have an idea involving bundling scrap metal with rope and just launching it” Adora said in a serious tone, trying to convey that she will be helping the garrison with this task.

It took a few moments for Cithria to realize what Adora meant, she then nodded and turned to the others. “Go grab some spare scrap metal and rope! Make it quick!” Cithria barked the orders to the troops before she began to show Adora the massive walls that were outside the dome. Massive amounts of artillery and anti-siege equipment line the walls, with Catapults crowning the ramparts of the walls and many carved holes with ballistas poking out of them.

A thought began to grow in Adora's mind, was this place meant to keep out…or keep them *in* . These poor folk lack even the access to the sky, they rely on artificial light and have to be loyal to those who rule and-

Where was the Mayor?

"Erm? Your majesty?" Cithria said, leaning to the side as Adora realized she was staring out into the sandy lands before her. Adora shook her head and pinched the bridge of her nose before exhaling gently, she turned to look at Cithria. "We are NOT enough" Adora said as she began to walk past Cithria.

Cithria began to stammer "do you wish for us to experiment and upgrade the defenses while you go do your…thing?" she said to which Adora stopped, looked at Cithria and nodded. "I am going to have a chat with the mayor. See if I can get a militia started. There's so many people here, they should fight for their homes" Adora said, a tad bit too grim for Cithria's taking but she didn't object to additional help.

Adora, this time, made the wise decision to summon Swift Wind to fly her back to the mansion to find the Mayor. She needed to get a militia going, their coalition numbers were not enough to cover such a large city. A City twice the size of Brightmoon's titular capital city, but many layers dense. It was easy for Adora to forget that this City was stacked high, with many of its buildings nearly touching the immense sandstone ceiling that covers the entire city which is miles above her head even as she flies with Swift Wind.

“Hey Swifty?” Adora idly asked as they were flying.

“What’s up Adora?” Swift Wind asked while focusing on flying ahead.

“Were you able to find out why no one has seen the Mayor?” Adora asked as they flew, catching the attention of those beneath them.

“Aaaand you’re asking me becaaaause?” Swift Wind said with a small smirk.

“Because you can translate for animals, Swifty!” Adora exclaimed with a roll of her hand and a silly smirk. Swift Wind let out a small but cheerful huff as he rolled his eyes. He then furrowed his brow and explained some…interesting details.

“Well, yeah everyone here is just keeping appearances. The Mayor actually is quite the dictator, pretty much all the citizens are essentially prisoners. Unable to ever leave the city, He’s got secret police all over the city to keep them in line. The Mayor’s dog told me every single detail” Swift Wind explained, much to Adora’s shock.

“Well then why did he join The Coalition? Slithermaw was literally the first city to join us!” Adora cried out in outrage, already feeling the warmth of rage surge through her. This was an outrage, Adora would have never supported a tyrannical government, let alone one who would never allow its citizens to leave their own city.

“I dunno, but maybe we should get it out of him? The Mayor’s back at his personal manor!” Swift Wind said as Adora nodded. It was about damn time that they got to the bottom of this, Swift Wind landed in front of the Manor and Adora disembarked. Perfuma was standing out front in the Manor’s artificial-looking garden. A series of rusted pipes sprinkling water constantly over long since drowned plants, she seemed…distant.

“Perfuma, where’s the mayor?” Adora said approaching Perfuma, she stopped in her tracks when she saw how despondent she was. “I should have seen it…but He doesn’t care about the citizens. He doesn’t care about them at all. In fact…like these plants…he would rather kill them before he would let them go” Perfuma stated distantly, she shook her head before looking at Adora.

“In his office” Perfuma said, her eyes were glassy and her frame shook gently. “Perfuma? Are you okay?” Adora extended a hand towards Perfuma, her face wrought with concern as Perfuma then suddenly hugged Adora and trembled.

“I’m scared Adora…I really am. This whole war is a nightmare” Perfuma said in a voice that was barely a whisper. Adora sighed gently and returned the hug to Perfuma before letting her go. Adora made her way into the office, going past servants and guards. Adora forced the door open with an audible crack.

The Office was full of smoke from cigarettes, The Mayor was a fat man in a dirty suit. His slightly balding head was slick with nervous sweat while his pudgy fingers were adorned with various bejeweled rings and his beady little eyes were suddenly locked onto Adora’s angry figure.

“O-oh! Q-Queen Adora?? I thought you were helping the Coalition set up the defenses!” The Mayor stammered as he sat up in his chair. Adora rolled her neck before slammed her hands onto the desk and glared at him. “So…you’re a damn tyrant huh?”

The Mayor’s pale face flushed; he went to open his mouth but Adora cut him off. “I have my ways, why did you join the damn Coalition? If I had known about this, I would have let Gareth seize this city…”she said with a growl.

The Mayor shuddered grotesquely before he let out a response. “Because i’m fucking afraid…I heard what Minox did to the first city he seized. A Slaver city called Anarax. A erm…bottom class family sold their son into slavery so they could live wealthily, its not a…” The Mayor gulped and dabbed a handkerchief to his head “a rare occurrence here in the wastes. But The Son fled from his master and came across Minox and a patrol of soldiers.”

Adora raised an eyebrow but said nothing…yet.

“The Son was instantly recruited and Minox violently seized Anarax, The Son just…slaughtered the family that sold him along with the two adopted children his birth parents adopted. Then Minox enacted a practice Gareth had devised to punish slavers and their families. They called it *Hrottaskur* ” The Mayor explained with a shaky voice, he had a very hard time trying to pronounce the Ziadrothan word.

“One in ten of the City’s citizenry, from the peasantry to the nobility and regardless of age, was elected by a lottery to be brutally killed by their peers with nothing but their bare hands.

This was enforced by the freed slaves who were just…" The Mayor leaned back and waved one of his fat hands "just armed and armored by these insane Ziadrothans. Anyone who didn't comply was killed. So in doing so, an entire 10th of the city's non-slave population was executed. The Slaves became Ziadrothan citizens and the city was brought under their control."

The Mayor sighed and looked Adora in her eyes. "So…when I heard that is what happens to *every fucking city* that is seized by Ziadroth…I joined the Coaltion in a heartbeat. Because they will see me and everyone here as no better than slavers…we're the biggest slave city in the wastes and the Emperor WILL have a very special way of making us the example."

Adora said nothing for a minute as a clock ticked gently in the smoky room. She leaned forward with arms crossed. "Well then Mayor, we need numbers. My coalition soldiers aren't enough. I'm sure the noble houses will provide better recruits than the peasantry as you put it. I need at least 200,000 soldiers armed and given command over to me within 3 days. The Emperor himself is coming and if you want me to guarantee your safety, I need plenty of soldiers." Adora hissed with a voice full of icy venom.

The Mayor soundlessly nodded "o-o-of course. I can do that…I will do that" he said as he pulled out a book of contact information as Adora leaned back and made her way to the door. "Good…now I'm going to finish what I need to do." Adora grimly said before she exited the room and slammed the door behind her.

Adora knew that the nobility and the Mayor would have tried to use the oppressed people if she didn't exactly specify soldiers of a noble background. If they make it out of this, perhaps the vast number of noble casualties will help the Coalition free Slithermaw from oppression and quietly dispose of its corrupt aspects.

Adora escorted Perfuma back to her quarters before taking Swift Wind and flying over to the Northern Wall to see what Cithria's progress was. She would see from the ramparts a few balls of tied up scrap metal poking out of small craters in the sand. Adora approached Cithria and crossed her arms. "So? Any progress?" Adora asked Cithria who stood at attention and saluted.

"My Queen, the scrap metal ammunition seems to work great!" Cithria said with a big and eager smile. Adora walked past Cithria and leaned on the sandstone rampart. She let the warm wind blow past her features for a few moments. "Good, that's Good Cithria." Adora said warmly, looking over her shoulder and locking eyes with Cithria.

"Did you get the numbers we need to help save Slithermaw?" Cithria asked inquisitively to which Adora nodded, turning to fully look at Cithria. "We're going to get a lot of soldiers, though they will be inadequately equipped and poorly trained…it'll have to do." Adora explained "besides we got a few days and-"

Suddenly the air grew cold as the wind began to blow more and more violently. Adora's blood went cold as she could see horror painted on Cithria's face, gazing towards the sky behind Adora's head. Adora slowly turned her head to see a rapidly approaching black storm full of crackling lightning. *Golden. Lightning.*

Adora could feel the drops of rain smack against her skin, soaking into her jacket and onto the Sandstone. As the wind bit into her skin she slowly lowered her head into the Horizon. With every crackle of lightning she gazed upon a mountain range that drew closer and closer. It was then she realized that wasn’t a fucking mountain range.

It was a line of the biggest vehicles she had ever seen in her life. The next thing she heard was Gareth’s voice, enhanced by magic, singing. Along with the voices of 1 million other warriors.

Treads a' rolling on the crimson rivers

Blood and glory in the fighting fields

Bones a' shatter into splintered timbers

Iron and steel

Fires are rising and the guns are ringing

Glory take us into Odin's halls

Golden glimmer and the sound of singing

Asgard's call

Oh-ho-oh

The echoes of etheria

Oh-ho-oh

Ziadroth calling me

Oh-ho-oh

To cut the strings of destiny

Oh-ho-oh

Ziadroth calling me

Ziadroth calling me 1

1 Lyrics based on Johnathan Young's "Valhalla Calling"

Chapter 5: Fall of Slithermaw

Chapter 5:

Fall of Slithermaw

Almost instantly, the city began to drown in sheer panic. The screams of terror resounded against the dome of the city, it was practically deafening as Adora used her power to enhance her sight. Each of the Landships had their massive fronts hiss before lowering and slamming into the red sands with a thunderous boom.

A crimson tide of Ziadrothan warriors emerged from the Landships that were equal parts fortress and war machine. The thundering of numerous machines rolled off the ramps, Tanks, APCs and fearsome looking vehicles that Adora had never seen before. These large machines formed a large line at the rear of the army, she could see massive spider-legs emerge from the sides and anchor themselves into the ground.

"What the fuck…" Adora muttered in half-shock and half-disbelief, as all of the Coalition soldiers began to man the walls. To their credit, they managed to rally volunteers as not all of the citizens had succumbed to sheer panic. Using the city intercoms they managed to rally more and more volunteers…they were poorly equipped with basic weapons and armor…but it had to do.

Adora saw massive spiked tubes emerge from the spines of the machines and point upwards towards the sky, that was when Adora realized what those were… *Artillery batteries and far bigger than the kind the Horde once fielded* "GET THE FUCK DOWN!!!!!!"

Adora roared, unintentionally using her powers to amplify her voice. Everyone began to seek cover as the ground thudded gently and thunder echoed across the air, each time the Artillery batteries fired, the very ground shook and the shells…the shells *screamed* as they impacted the Domed city itself with the wrath of an angry god.

A massive warcry was heard from the crimson tide as it began to charge forward, the 1-million warrior army charged with weapons blazing as the vehicles began to take pot-shots as they drew closer and closer to the city itself. In comparison to the energy weapons of the Horde, Ziadroth used ballistic weapons and while it is a downgrade compared to the Horde…the sheer amount of missiles, bullets and tank shells that were ripping into the walls pretty much negated any debate of which provided more rapid and loud firepower.

Adora ducked her head to dodge a few stray rounds, they were barely in range, such high rate of fire weapons could barely hit them from where they were. Especially so far away, in fact. only the Artillery were making accurate blows, but that wasn't the objective, this was terror through sheer force of might.

Gazing to the left to see a few coalition soldiers screaming and holding their ears, Cithria included, even though no injuries had struck them. They were buckling before the enemy even got close, she needed to get out there and meet the enemy head on. Draw their fire so that the defenders could actually rally for when the Ziadrothans actually got within range of the defenses

Adora glanced out over the ramparts again and with her enhanced sight she could see a trio of commanders leading the charge from

the front. Scorpia, Minox and Gareth. Adora gritted her teeth and pulled out her sword "BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

With a mighty flash of light, She-Ra had entered the fight.

Gareth could see the distant flash of light from where he was marching, he wondered if Scorpia and Minox saw it too but he couldn't be sure. The adrenaline pumped through his veins as he felt alive in the sheer thrill of an almighty siege. Scorpia was smiling all the way as she walked beside him, Minox shifted his eyes towards the many soldiers firing their weapons as they ran past each other like a bunch of barbarians. Despite a tinge of revulsion stemming from his past Horde indoctrination, he had to admit that he hadn't thought of such a… *bold* tactic.

Very few of the Coalition were prepared for such a display of might, hell even some lucky coalition soldiers maybe catching bullets as they walked, but only time would tell. The artillery boomed and caused the sand to rumble with every blast, and it was a veritable wall of death those Artillery batteries had formed up in their position. Their firing was rhythmatic, almost akin to a song… *almost* .

There was a huge crack, a sonic boom as something began to soar through the air and began making its way towards them. "When did Brightmoon get artillery shells?!" Minox let out a roar of surprise, Gareth squinted his eyes before they shot open in sudden surprise. "That's not a fucking shell!" Gareth yelled, Scorpia and Minox ducked out of the way just as She-Ra came down like the wrathful fist of an angry god onto Gareth.

Adora’s sword collided with Gareth’s greataxe with a thunderous clap, the very air exploding around them. Gareth grit his teeth as his emerald eyes locked onto Adora’s sapphire eyes, both holding the expression of endless rage and the fury of warriors. “Hey *Gareth* ” Adora snarled as she began to push Gareth back with every pressing step.

“ *Sister* ” Gareth said with vitriol and venom in his voice before he opened his mouth and drew a glowing circle in his mouth. Adora was briefly confused before Gareth let out a roar and the air that passed through the circle became a violent burst of flames. Adora stumbled back in surprise and pain before Gareth flipped out his triple-barreled sawed off and fired all three barrels to send She-ra flying back a significant distance. Her body tumbled across the sand like a tumbleweed before she stopped herself with her sword. The pellets embedded in her skin were covered up by her healing factor, leaving tricklets of blood behind.

Scorpia was about to let out a cheer and a whoop for Gareth but something caught the attention of her and Minox. They both turned their heads to gaze upon the Gate of Slithermaw itself ripped open and a weaponized mass of citizens, crimson wasters and brightmoon soldiers flooded out of the gate. Assisted by Plumeran sorcerers who summoned vast plants to lash out at the oncoming swarm of Ziadrothan firepower.

Many on both sides began to drop like flies. Minox snarled in sheer confusion “the fuck is happening?!” he roared in Ziadrothan before a spear struck him in the shoulder causing the Minotaur to cry out in anger and pain. Huntara lunged forward with a pair of sickles and slashed at the minotaur’s legs, the bladed sickles loudly scraped against his titanic crimson armor. “We’re fighting back fucker!” Huntara said with a confidence that was unlike her.

Scorpia stumbled back before cocking her head towards the gate. She gazed upon the reason for the sudden incursion of reinforcements…there standing and surrounded by a magical shield was none other than the head sorceress of Mystacor, Castaspella. Behind her? Well there was an immense rift, the citizens of Slithermaw that did not wish to fight or could not fight fled into the rift and able bodied soldiers from across the Coalition surged forward.

"Uh oh…" Scorpia said, *this was going to present some problems* . Scorpia then readied herself and charged, shoulder slamming into two Brightmoon soldiers with incredible force. Scorpia heard their rib cages crunch under the sheer force of her attack and with a backhand blow with her claw, she sent the soldiers flying into the sand ahead of her. Suddenly the ground shook and massive thorny vines erupted from the ground and attempted to crush her.

Scorpia, however, was not going to let that happen as she used her claws and training to reduce the oncoming vines into chunks. She gazed upon Perfuma, the illumination of the fires engulfing Slithermaw and the chaotic battle around them, giving the normally peaceful princess of Plumera the appearance of one of those Valkyries that Gareth described. She looked… *not bad at all* . "I'm usually a healer, but I've hit my limit! so…so…sCREW YOU!" Perfuma yelled and did a diving punch onto Scorpia.

Scorpia stumbled back a couple feet and saw Perfuma wincing in pain, rubbing her wrist and muttering to herself. Scorpia sighed and stung Perfuma, knocking her out. "sorry…I guess you need some more training" Scorpia said, cringing at having to knock her out like that…not exactly a very Ziadrothan way to do things. Scorpia then looked from side to side and then meekly nudged Perfuma towards the Coalition-side of the battlefield before she went back towards the more rear part of the Ziadrothan

battlefront to relay further orders. While also trying to make sure she wasn't obviously shot by an arrow.

Adora and Gareth collided like titans, or more accurately gods, on the battlefield. Their blows sent the sand scattering around them and the very air to buckle and shatter beneath the sheer intensity of their blows. Neither the Emperor nor the Protector dared back down, lest the other take advantage of weaknesses.

"So! This was your plan huh?! It was never about the damned city! Just the people within its walls!" Gareth shouted, drawing circles into the air and causing bolts of lighting to fire from the circles. Adora deflected the bolts with her blade before slamming her foot into the ground, fracturing the very rock beneath, and swatting the chunks with the flat end of her blade. Making the rocks into impromptu projectiles.

Gareth used Bloodbane to cleave through the Rocks, just in time to see Adora slam her fist into Gareth's chest and send him tumbling backwards. Adora huffed and wiped some blood off her lip with the back of her hand. "Pretty much…you were going to raze this city to the fucking ground. Besides, your empire outnumbers the Coalition ten to one! I need the numbers to fight the war, a war *YOU* decided to unleash!" Adora yelled in rage as Gareth stood back up and rolled his neck.

The cocking of machine guns suddenly grabbed Adora's attention as a sizable squad of soldiers had decided to intervene for the Emperor. Gareth extended his clawed gauntlet-covered right hand towards them "press on with the assault, She-Ra is mine" he said with a snarl before spitting out a glob of blood. The soldiers obeyed and continued.

“I admit, it's a decent plan, one small issue though…” Gareth said as he stood up and re-assumed his combat position. Gareth pointed over to Adora’s shoulder, Adora looked over her shoulder to see the casualties that were mounting up as Ziadroth pressed on its advance. Her eyes went wide as she saw that The Coalition was swiftly losing ground, even the nigh-impenetrable magic shields that Mystacor mages were known for were buckling under the sheer amount of firepower the Ziadrothans were spewing from their weapons.

“Even your most mightiest soldiers can’t match up against the numbers I command. Now you have a choice, Adora. Either continue fighting and possibly lose more than you ever dared hope to achieve…or, retreat and cash in what you got” Gareth said with a cruel smile and a gentle pant.

Adora turned her head and charged with a battle cry and slammed her sword down at Gareth who dodged out of the way. Gareth slammed the bladed pommel of his sword into Adora’s nose, causing a sizable gush of blood to come out. Adora stumbled back and snarled, The longer she fought, more would die. Ziadroth won either way.

Huntara slammed her sickle into the bare chest of Minox who brayed in pain, she was becoming exhausted fast and yet this Minotaur was barely affected by the fatigue of battle. “You’re going to die, Minox! One way or another!” Huntara shouted before Minox roared and slammed his head into her face, sending her backwards and onto the sand. Her vision became dazed as Huntara realized that Minox had sent her flying into a rock.

“Hvernig væri að ég tæki pundið af holdi af þér?1” Minox snarled in the tongue of Ziadroth and flung one of his axes at Huntara. Due to being dazed, Huntara could barely react when the thrown

axe strikes her with a sickening crunch. Huntara cried out in pain and stood up, her left side was burning up and it felt wet, the crimson waster went to reach for the sickle on her left while maintaining eye contact with Minox. Her face was wrought with confusion when she couldn't pick it up, Huntara looked at her left side to see that her entire left arm was severed.

Huntara let out a cry of anguish as she realized the dire medical situation she was in. Minox grinned wickedly and howled before charging at her, horns lowered for a swift and messy kill. Only for him to be struck in the face by a thorned root which sent him scattering into the sands. She saw Perfuma, who was exhausted and dazed. "We need to go…now…" Perfuma said to Huntara, using some of her magic to bind some vines around the bleeding stump that Huntara had for a left shoulder.

"ADORA! Huntara's missing an arm! Casta's magic shield is failing! If she can't maintain the shield then she loses control of the rift! We have to go now!" Perfuma yelled into the earpiece Adora had. Adora parried a blow from Gareth as she heard this, it was clear from Gareth's expression that Adora had utterly failed to hide her shock and horror. Gareth smirked and shouldered his Great axe. "I'd start running then" Gareth mused cruelly.

Adora ran like hell as the city's entire ceiling collapsed and now Slithermaw's entire city was being shelled by the Ziadrothan Artillery. Upon seeing She-Ra make a run for the rift, the many Coalition Soldiers began to make a run too. The Ziadrothans swiftly noticed a retreat in progress and began to fire upon the retreating soldiers and civilians, constantly cutting down many of them as they tried to reach safety.

Gareth began to laugh and spread his arms out as he saw the city itself crumble under the might of his empire. The victory cries of his warriors rang out in the air, somehow drowning even the metric ton of firepower that was saturating the atmosphere with shells, bullets, blood and flames.

Scorpia watched in awe as the battle had been one, her first military campaign had come to an end. She walked over to an inactive tank, sat next to it and let out a relieved sigh. She was going to need a break after all this, and she wondered how many others would be excited to come home after the battle as well.

Adora, Perfuma, Huntara, Swift Wind, *who had been using his efforts to evacuate people within the city* , along with the surviving members of the Coalition forces had made it towards the Rift. Castaspella had looked worn out as she barely was holding back the firepower. "Thank goodness, I don't think I could have held it back much longer" Castaspella tiredly stated, her body shuddered gently as the remaining civilians, especially the armed ones still fighting…had realized the situation. They began to scream, to yell and beg at the coalition to stay and fight, even if these brave souls were but a fifth of the population and the rest had already escaped.

Adora made one of the toughest decisions of her career as Queen…and ordered the rift to be sealed behind them once all the coalition soldiers had made it, the ones that were still alive or considered alive of course. They couldn't go and get the bodies of the fallen, Adora mounted Swift wind and flew into the portal.

Within a few minutes, all coalition forces had retreated into the portal and the portal had been sealed. Leaving the remaining Slithermaw Citizens, both armed and unarmed, who hadn't been

able to evacuate in the hands of Ziadroth. Adora may not have realized it at the time, but she also left behind a small number of wounded Coalition soldiers, those that had somehow survived the brutal assault of the Ziadrothans in their cruel barbarian hands.

The gunfire and shelling, after a brutal 4 hour siege, finally fell silent and the victory cries of the legions of Ziadroth echoed around. The City of Slithermaw resembled an egg who's entire western side had been cracked open, with the Ziadrothans moving into the city and looting it. Slithermaw citizens were rounded up, many of them had been killed by the rubble and artillery shells before they could be accessed by Ziadrothans. Entire families fearing for their lives preferred to have been destroyed in the battle than whatever fate Gareth had in mind for them.

Gareth sat in the Mayor's office, enjoying some of the mayor's finer spirits, due to being so far into the city, it was spared the destruction that the front of the city had received. The sun was setting as the wounded Coalition Soldiers were being executed, and many Ziadroth Warriors began to take trophies from the dead. Both Coalition and otherwise.

Gareth leaned back in the spacious chair the Mayor owned and pulled out a photo of himself and Catra from a pocket in his armor. He smiled gently at the smile his wife has in the picture, he couldn't wait to see her again. A sudden commotion caught Gareth's attention as a trio of soldiers brought in a obese man in a dirty suit. Gareth placed the photo away and Gareth leaned forward on the desk.

"Ah, Sergeant. What do you have for me?" Gareth said with a smile and an amicable attitude. The Soldier nodded towards his

two companions who forced the man onto his knees. The obese man was shuddering from head to toe in pure fear. He was sweaty and he had a musk about him that suggested that he had been through rigorous exercise.

"My Emperor. This is the Mayor of Slithermaw. He was caught trying to escape the city, but we managed to catch him before he was able to do so. I wanted advice on how we should deal with him" The Soldier said plainly and professionally.

Gareth got up from the desk and grabbed his greataxe, before the Mayor could say another word, Gareth slammed Bloodbane into the Mayor's head. Which split him vertically in half up until the waist. The blood of the mayor was absorbed into the Axe and the fearsome-looking skull which held an amber crystal-eye in its mouth began to glow fiercely for a few seconds.

"Leave him to rot. We're going home…" Gareth simply said.

1Translation: "how's about I take my pound of flesh from you?"

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